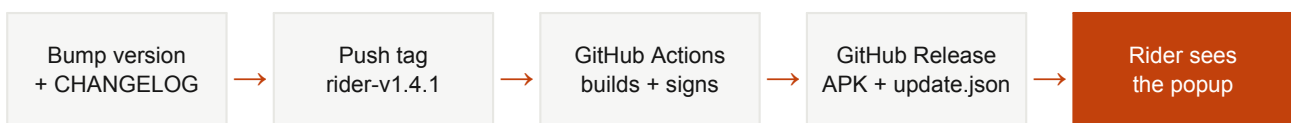


PM Rider Android: Release & Update Guide

How the rider APK updates itself from GitHub Releases, and how to ship a new version safely. Read this once before your first release. Details live in `docs/RIDER_APP_RELEASES.md`.

1. The big picture

The rider app is the React code in `rider/`, wrapped as an Android app with **Capacitor**. We don't use the Play Store. Instead, every release is a **signed APK on GitHub Releases**, and the app checks there and updates itself. The browser version (PWA) is separate and updates with every server deploy, so this guide is only about the APK.

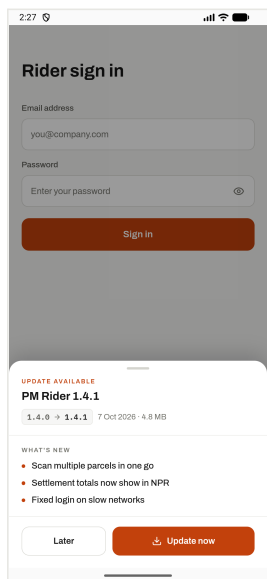


Releases happen only when you push a tag

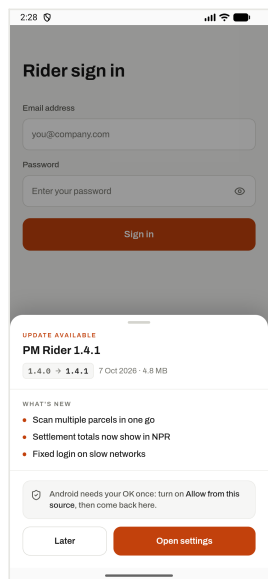
Merging to `main` never publishes an APK, even if you changed `rider/`. You decide when riders get an update by pushing a `rider-v*` tag.

2. What the rider sees

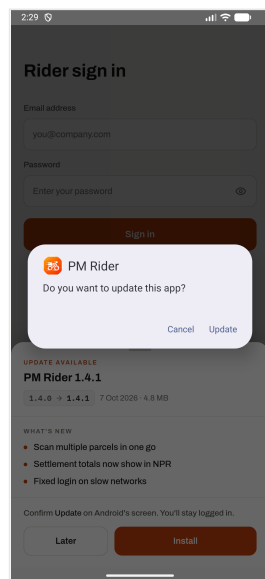
The app checks for updates on every launch (and when it comes back to the foreground, at most every 6 hours). Riders can also tap **Profile** → **Check for updates**. After the rider confirms, Android replaces the app **in place**, so they stay logged in and keep their settings. Play Protect may first show "App scan recommended". Tapping **Scan app** → **Install** is safe. **Later** hides the popup for 24 hours.



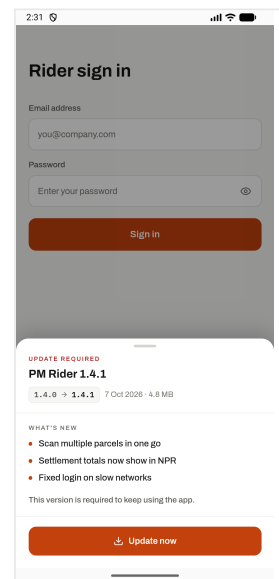
1. Popup version, date, size and "What's new" from CHANGELOG



2. First time only allow installs from PM Rider



3. Android confirms "update this app?" means an in-place update



Required update no "Later" button

3. Ship a release in 5 steps

1 Bump the version in rider/package.json

```
cd rider
npm version 1.4.1 --no-git-tag-version
```

2 Write the rider-facing notes in rider/CHANGELOG.md

Add a new section at the top, under the intro. These bullets are exactly what riders read in the popup, so keep them short and plain (no ticket numbers).

```
## 1.4.1 – 2026-10-20
– Scan multiple parcels in one go
– Fixed login on slow networks
```

3 Check it (optional, CI runs the same check)

```
node scripts/release-manifest.mjs check rider-v1.4.1
```

4 Merge to main, then tag and push the tag

```
git checkout main && git pull
git tag rider-v1.4.1
git push origin rider-v1.4.1
```

5 Watch it ship

GitHub → **Actions** → **Rider APK release**. In about 5 minutes, **Releases** shows **pm-rider-1.4.1.apk** and **update.json**. Riders get the popup on their next launch.

4. Rules you must not break

Never lose or replace the signing key

Every APK must be signed with the same key. A different key means Android refuses the update, and every rider has to uninstall (and log in again). The key is in GitHub secrets and in an offline backup. Don't regenerate it.

Rule	Why
Only change the version in rider/package.json	Gradle reads it from there. Editing build.gradle by hand breaks the version check.
Versions only go up, and each part stays 0–99	versionCode = MAJOR×10000 + MINOR×100 + PATCH (1.4.1 = 10401). Android ignores updates that aren't higher.
Tag must equal the version: rider-v1.4.1	CI refuses mismatches so a tag can't ship the wrong build.
Batch small fixes	Every rider change (even text) is a full APK the rider must tap through. Fewer, fuller releases are kinder.

5. Required updates

When the server stops supporting old app versions (for example, after an API change), add `(required)` to the changelog heading:

```
## 1.5.0 – 2026-11-01 (required)
```

Riders on any older version then get the popup with **no "Later" button**. Use this sparingly.

6. What CI checks

The workflow is [.github/workflows/rider-release.yml](#). If a release fails, the error in the Actions log tells you which check failed:

Check	Fails when
Anything changed?	<code>rider/</code> is identical to the previous <code>rider-v*</code> tag
Tag vs version	The tag doesn't match <code>rider/package.json</code>
Changelog	No <code>## 1.4.1</code> section, or it has no bullets
Signing key	Secrets are missing, or the APK isn't signed with the key riders have installed
versionCode	The built APK's versionCode doesn't match package.json

7. Where the code lives

File	What it does
<code>rider/src/components/UpdateSheet.tsx</code>	The popup UI
<code>rider/src/context/UpdateContext.tsx</code>	Update flow: check → download → permission → install
<code>rider/src/lib/appUpdater.ts</code>	Manifest URL, types, 6-hour throttle, "Later" snooze
<code>rider/android/.../AppUpdaterPlugin.java</code>	Native side: download, SHA-256 + signature checks, installer
<code>rider/android/app/build.gradle</code>	Version from package.json, release signing
<code>rider/scripts/release-manifest.mjs</code>	Builds <code>update.json</code> + release notes from CHANGELOG
<code>rider/CHANGELOG.md</code>	The "What's new" text riders see

8. Testing the updater on an emulator

Debug builds can read the manifest over plain HTTP from your machine (release builds require HTTPS):

```
export VITE_RIDER_UPDATE_MANIFEST_URL=http://localhost:8765/update.json
npm run build && npx cap sync android && (cd android && ./gradlew assembleDebug)
adb install -r android/app/build/outputs/apk/debug/app-debug.apk
# build a higher-version APK + update.json into ~/upd, then:
cd ~/upd && python3 -m http.server 8765 &
adb reverse tcp:8765 tcp:8765
```

The full recipe is in [docs/RIDER_APP_RELEASES.md](#).

9. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause and fix
"App not installed" / "package conflicts"	The installed app has a different key (old debug build). Uninstall once, then install from Releases.
No popup after a release	The release isn't marked Latest , or the phone is offline. Profile → Check for updates shows the error.
"Signed with a different key"	Someone changed the CI keystore secret. Restore the original key.
Old screens right after updating from ≤ 1.3	Old builds cached the PWA. 1.4.0+ clears it at startup, and the next launch is clean.

Moving from the old builds (one time)

APKs up to 1.3 were debug builds signed on one laptop. Riders on those must uninstall once and install 1.4.0 from the Releases page. From then on, every update comes through the popup.